FRONTIER LANDS

At the age of nearly sixty, Akbar was still a force of nature, the wounds from a lifetime of battles soldered together by his iron will and robust health. To his sons and his soldiers he appeared indestructible, for no sign of weakness was ever allowed to show. The army that Akbar rode in front of was just as formidable as the Padshah. It would have included hundreds of camel guns and many thousand rockets, in addition to conventional artillery, muskets, and archers. ‘The lumbering siege trains of the stereotypical “Gunpowder Empire,” tethered to a few gigantic cannon, were nowhere in evidence.’ Despite the rough and unknown nature of the countryside as they marched to the Deccan, the Mughal army was able to move huge numbers of soldiers almost seamlessly across the country because of the extensive and detailed organization of its supplies and equipment. An additional tax was levied on all agricultural holdings, the proceeds of which were used to stock thanas* throughout the empire. These could be mobilized in times of famine but, more often, were used to supply rations for the travelling army. Manufactured goods required for the army, such as weapons and ammunitions, were made in kar khanas. A great deal of the provisions were carried with the army, organized by the mir bakawal. In addition, ready cash was carried to pay for all supplies that would need to be bought along the way. Armies were accompanied by merchants, who sold commodities, and bankers, like the Marwaris in Bengal, who sometimes advanced money to the governor of campaigns to be able to finance the battles. The existence of immense mobile encampments meant that the troops did not have to forage, plunder, or requisition quarters in villages along the way, the entire army being provided for and moving en bloc.

The size of the army was meant to serve as a deterrent to all those who contemplated resistance. The sharp end of the fighting was being carried out by Daniyal, and his substantial but smaller forces. Having subdued Ahmadnagar, the prince travelled first through Khandesh, and arrived at the capital, Burhanpur, where there were ominous signs that the Raja of Burhanpur, Bahadur Shah, supposedly an ally of the Mughals, was not in a